

9.3.1 vBulletin

vBulletin is a great forum package—one of the most popular forum packages, which is surprisingly efficient as well. It's been written completely in PHP. The backend database uses MySQL. Some of the salient features of V Bulletin:

1. It's scalable, and the database server and Web servers can be discrete machines.
2. Utilises MySQL as a backend, which is ultra-light on resources and hence fast.
3. All the advantages of PHP, that is, platform independence, cross-platform, and so on. In fact, the main advantage is that it shares a very significant trait with PHP—efficiency.
4. Advanced features for threads such as active users thread showing, new post indicator via PM, thread subscribing, post rating and polling, advanced admin tools for threads such as move, edit, delete, lock, quick replies, post previews, advanced text and MM signatures, extended smileys, and avatars.

vBulletin is paid software; a license costs \$160 (Approx Rs. 7200). It's available for download once you've paid and registered, with easy-to-follow steps in the online help file. You will need to visit the members area, <http://members.vbulletin.com>, which should provide adequate support for even first-time users.

Once the archive has downloaded, you simply extract it. Note that at this point you'll need to have Easy PHP installed—or PHP, MySQL and Apache individually. You should now see two folders in your vBulletin directory, namely “do_not_upload” and “upload”. The “upload” folder contains the files to be uploaded to your Web server. Before uploading, rename the `config.php.new` file in the “includes” folder to “`config.php`”. The “do_not_upload” folder contains tools that allow you to perform tasks on the board. There is a “`tools.php`” that has to be uploaded to the “`admincp`” folder. This is an emergency-use only file, and should be deleted immediately after use or it will cause a severe security problem.